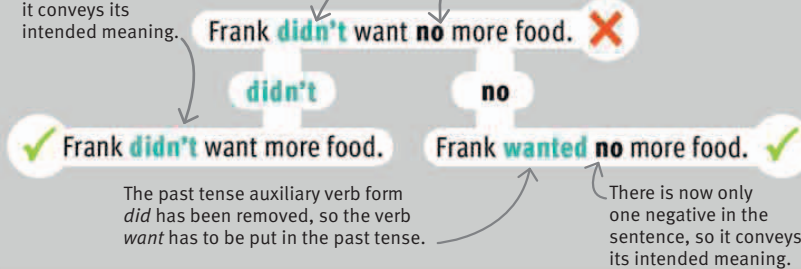


Identifying a double negative

A double negative is when two negative words appear in a single clause. Although the two negative words are usually intended to convey a single negative thought—and this usage is understood in colloquial English—in reality, one negative plus another negative equals a positive. If a clause includes two negative words, one of them should be removed.

There is now only one negative in the sentence, so it conveys its intended meaning.

There are two negatives in this sentence, so the resulting meaning is that Frank did want more food.



GLOSSARY

Auxiliary verb A “helping” verb like *be* or *have* that connects the main verb in a sentence to the subject. These are the only verbs that can be made negative.

Clause A grammatical unit that contains a subject and a verb. Sentences are made up of one or more clauses.

• **Not** is the most common negative word, but other words can be used in the same way. These range from *never* and *no*, the most forceful, to *seldom*, *barely*, and *hardly*, which reflect smaller degrees of negativity.

Negative pronouns

Some indefinite pronouns are already in a negative form, and therefore don't need to be made negative using *not*. These include *nobody*, *no one*, *nothing*, and *none*.

Nobody could believe he wouldn't try a curried sausage.

There is no need to add the word *not* after this auxiliary verb, because *nobody* is a negative word.

Nobody is a singular pronoun, so the verb must be singular.

restaurant before. **Nobody could**
sausage. He **disliked** spicy food.

Positive thinking

Most statements use fewer words and are more convincing if they are written in a positive way. Even negative words can be used in a positive sentence structure.

This negative word means “did not like,” but it can be used in a positive sentence.

He disliked
spicy food.

Negative structure	Positive structure
did not like	disliked
was not honest	was dishonest
did not pay attention	ignored
could not remember	forgot
did not start on time	started late
is not attractive	is unattractive